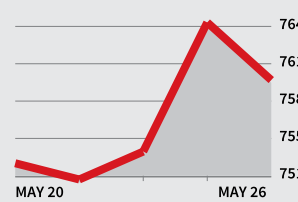


SENSEX 76009.70 (-479.26)

IN FOCUS



	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23913.70	-118.00
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.45	-0.12
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.68	+0.45
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	156980.00	-1241
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	266213.00	-4887

DEBT DIGITISATION.

SEBI plans a pilot to tokenise bonds using distributed ledger tech to deepen and modernise India's corporate debt market **p6**



DATA FOCUS.

Banks' education loan

portfolio jumped 15% in FY26 to a decade-high of ₹8.58 lakh cr **p2**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

MISSING THE DATE

Storm over Bay may delay monsoon onset in Kerala



Thiruvananthapuram: The India Meteorological Department (IMD) model guidance now suggests that conditions for a classical monsoon onset are unlikely to fall into place before June 5. The delay stems largely from disrupted upper-level winds, influenced by a developing storm system over the east Bay of Bengal. **p10**

GOING LEAN

Regional carriers tighten non-fuel costs, cut flights

Mumbai: Regional carriers are curtailing flights by 3-8 per cent and rationalising non-fuel expenses as high crude oil prices and weak rupee hurt their earnings. The airlines have cut a handful of flights, and are monitoring the cost and demand situation. **p12**

Glitches, hack claims put CBSE exam portal under the scanner

NO CLASS. Std XII answer-sheet mix-up, scoring discrepancies, contested security claims force govt to order probe by IIT

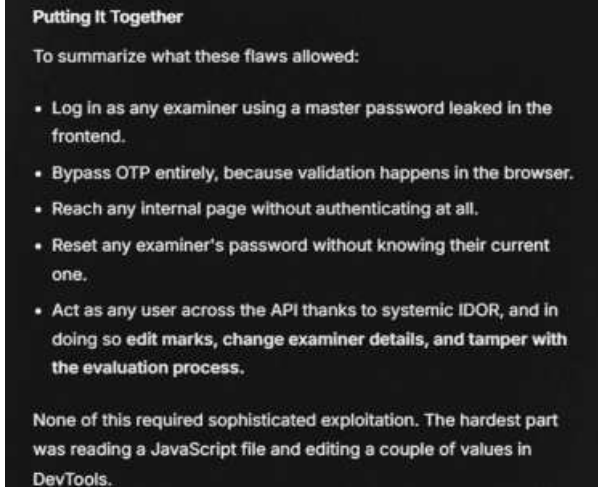
Our Bureaus

The CBSE's ambitious shift to digital evaluation for the Class 12 board exams has come under scrutiny after answer-sheet mix-ups, scoring discrepancies and contested security claims triggered a government-ordered IIT audit ahead of key admission deadlines.

A team from IIT-M is currently in Delhi to examine the On-Screen Marking (OSM) system, with IIT-M Director V Kamakoti saying the institute would soon have greater clarity on "where things went wrong".

COMPLAINTS GALORE

"There is a requirement for a third-party audit. They are also fighting against time because students need clarity to take the next steps for JEE and other admissions," Kamakoti said, adding that it was still unclear whether the problems stemmed from a



A screenshot from ethical hacker Nisarga Adhikary's blog

cyber attack or a system unable to handle traffic loads.

The audit comes amid a flood of complaints from students and parents about the CBSE's first full-scale use of OSM, under which scanned answer sheets are digitally evaluated rather than physical scripts.

Students have reported a

range of anomalies, including answer-sheets uploaded under the wrong roll numbers, blurred scanned pages, missing supplementary sheets, and scoring discrepancies.

The controversy widened after ethical hacker Nisarga Adhikary claimed he discovered vulnerabilities in the

OSM system, including what he described as a "master password" that could bypass authentication and potentially allow unauthorised access to marks.

The CBSE rejected the claim, saying the URL cited by the hacker was only a testing site with sample data and that "no security breaches have come to light" on the portal used for actual evaluation. Adhikary, however,

challenged the Board's explanation, saying he had screen recordings showing access to production data.

The OSM system is run by Coemopt Edu Teck, formerly Globarena Technologies, which faced similar controversy during Telangana's 2019 intermediate examination debacle. *businessline's* queries to Coemopt's CEO remain unanswered.

Also read p7

Flags ignored, says ethical hacker

S Ronendra Singh

New Delhi

Explaining the flaws in the CBSE portal, young ethical hacker Nisarga Adhikary says, "I discovered a hardcoded master password that could bypass all authentication, regardless of the user ID. [With this] I gained access to the main dashboard where I could edit students' marks. I recorded the entire

process and flagged it to CERT-In. Their response was a automated "thank you for reporting."

"A few days later, I reported five additional vulnerabilities. In response, they took the portal down for two-three days, removed the master password, and called it a day. But the remaining flaws were just as severe, and were left completely untouched. That is why I decided to go public."

Interview p7

Tata Sons board reviews loss-making units, group investment plans

Janaki Krishnan

Mumbai

At a crucial meeting in Bombay House on Tuesday, Tata Sons chairman N Chandrasekaran and other top officials made a detailed presentation to the members of the board on the performance of the group, its growth trajectory, capital allocation plans for emerging businesses, and the roadmap for turning around loss-making

companies, according to people aware of the matter.

The presentation dwelt, in particular, on the new areas that the Tata group has ventured into such as semiconductor manufacturing, iPhone assembly and precision electronics, and also the performance of Air India, Tata Digital, Agratas and Tejas Networks.

Air India posted a loss of \$2.8 billion in FY26, while companies under Tata Digital, such as Big Basket, 1mg

and Croma, have been struggling with cash flows and mounting losses.

EMERGING BUSINESSES

Sources described the presentations as "intense" and "detailed" with Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata, who is also on the board of Tata Sons, seeking information on several aspects. The discussions focused on the long-term strategy for these businesses, timelines for profitability and future in-

vestment commitments. The group has committed to spending over \$100 billion in its emerging businesses with a significant chunk allocated to Tata Electronics, an innovation hub in Navi Mumbai, and EV batteries.

No active decisions were understood to have been taken at the meeting, which was convened for the sole purpose of taking stock and for the senior management to make the presentation.

Apart from the board

members of Tata Sons, the heads of the new businesses are also understood to have attended the meeting, sources said.

In February, Noel Tata had raised the question of performance of some of the newer entities and had sought a comprehensive roadmap for the group from Chandrasekaran and greater clarity on the path to profitability of the loss-making entities.

The meeting comes at a

sensitive juncture for the conglomerate, with broader discussions underway on governance, succession planning and the future structure of Tata Sons, including the question of a potential listing.

Tensions are also rife between the members of Tata Trusts, setting the stage for a potential change in the composition of the Tata Sons board. The board is scheduled to meet on June 12 to review its annual accounts.

Quad counters China with \$20 b critical minerals plan



QUAD TALK. (from left) Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, Minister of External Affairs S Jaishankar, Japanese Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi, and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio at a joint press conference following the Quad Foreign Ministers' meeting in New Delhi **ANI**

Amiti Sen

New Delhi

To counter China's grip on the global supplies of critical minerals, the Quad partners — India, the US, Australia and Japan — on Tuesday announced a critical minerals framework to mobilise up to \$20 billion for strengthening supply chains.

The grouping also slammed Iran over tolling the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea.

Without directly naming China, the Quad Foreign Ministers raised serious concerns over "dangerous and coercive actions" in the East China Sea and the South China Sea, as well as the use of economic coercion and non-market policies, including arbitrary export restrictions, price manipulation, and supply disruptions, particularly in critical minerals.

"We underscore the importance of diversified and reliable global supply chains and the need to avoid reliance on any one country. To advance our vision, we are pleased to announce the Quad Critical Minerals Framework," the Quad Foreign Ministers said in a joint statement on Tuesday.

The meeting was hosted by External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and attended by

the Foreign Ministers of Australia Penny Wong and Japan Toshimitsu Motegi, as also the US Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

W. ASIA CONCERNS

The Ministers discussed the situation in West Asia and reaffirmed support for diplomatic efforts to bring peace in the region.

Making a case for the safe and uninterrupted flow of global commerce through the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea, the statement noted: "... We condemn the attacks on commercial shipping vessels and oppose any future measures that are inconsistent with UNCLOS, including imposition of tolls."

INDO-PACIFIC FOCUS

The Foreign Ministers also launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration (IPMSC) to boost information sharing and secure industrial supply chains.

The Quad will mobilise \$20 billion for critical minerals through public and private financing channels. The MEA said the funds will back strategic projects with a "Quad nexus" — located in partner countries or supplying Quad markets — to plug supply chain gaps.

Also read p3

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QUICKLY.

Refex Industries Q4 PAT
doubles to ₹100 crore



Chennai: Refex Industries has nearly doubled its consolidated profit after tax to ₹100 crore for Q4FY26, as against ₹46 crore in the year-ago quarter. For FY26, PAT stood at ₹204 crore. The board has recommended dividend of ₹1 per share for FY26, subject to the shareholders’ approval. **OUR BUREAU**

Dish TV Q4 net loss
narrows to ₹303.95 crore

New Delhi: Direct-to-home satellite television content distribution platform Dish TV India reported a narrowing of its consolidated net loss to ₹303.95 crore in the March quarter of FY26. The company had reported a net loss of ₹402.19 crore in the year-ago quarter, Dish TV said in a regulatory filing. Revenue from operations fell 29.27 per cent to ₹243.07 crore (₹343.66 crore). **PTI**

Hike in fuel prices to squeeze profit margin of cement cos

SPIRALLING COSTS. Higher fuel prices likely to push logistics cost up by ₹60-90/ tonne

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The sudden spike in petrol and diesel prices will push up the operational costs and squeeze the profit margins of cement companies as they look for a revival in demand to pass on the incremental costs. The government hiked petrol and diesel prices four times, effecting a cumulative rise of ₹7.50 per litre since May 15. Cement companies may be left to absorb major cost increase due to the intense competition in almost all key regions. Despite a revival in demand ahead of the monsoon, the recent fresh capacity additions by leading players will make it difficult for producers to implement a price hike. Cement companies have already undertaken price hikes of ₹10-20 per 50 kg bag in May on expectations of further fuel price hikes. Ashutosh Murarka, Cement Analyst, Choice Institutional Equities, said the re-



CAUSE AND EFFECT. Cement companies have already undertaken price hikes of ₹10-20 per 50 kg bag in May on expectations of further fuel price hikes

cent increase in fuel prices is expected to push up logistics cost by ₹60-90 a tonne. This apart, the higher imported pet coke and coal prices, driven by geopolitical tensions and elevated crude prices, are likely to further inflate fuel costs and result in overall cost increase of ₹250-350 a tonne, depending on fuel mix, lead distance and transportation exposure, he said. Companies with higher dependence on road logistics and imported fuel will witness a sharper cost escalation of ₹400-500 a tonne with major impact expected

from the September quarter, given the stock of low-cost inventory available with companies, said Murarka. **PRESSURE ON MARGINS** Saurabh Jain, Head of Fundamental Research, SMC Global Securities, said the fuel price rise is expected to exert pressure on cement sector margins in the near term. The cement producers’ ability to fully pass on incremental costs remains limited due to intense competition and ongoing capacity additions, particularly in south India, he said. Companies

with better operational efficiencies, higher renewable energy usage, improved fuel mix, premiumisation strategies and logistics optimisation are relatively better placed to manage cost pressures, he added. Manish Valecha, Co-Head - Research, Anand Rathii Institutional Equity, said the revival in demand in April had faded this month due to subdued sentiments driven by the ongoing West Asia conflict, delay in labourers’ return post-elections, intense heat, sand unavailability and poor agriculture output. If the war escalates, government infrastructure spending is also expected to be impacted, as it will prioritise social welfare expenditure over infrastructure, he said. Cement companies’ price hike attempts in May could not sustain due to weak sentiments, but they will continue the attempt as the upcoming monsoon will dampen demand further, limiting the scope for large price increases, said Valecha.

Education loan growth of banks touches 10-year high of 15% in FY26

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

Rising tuition fees, growing overseas education aspirations and wider lender participation pushed education loans from banks to their sharpest annual growth in a decade in FY26.

DATA FOCUS.

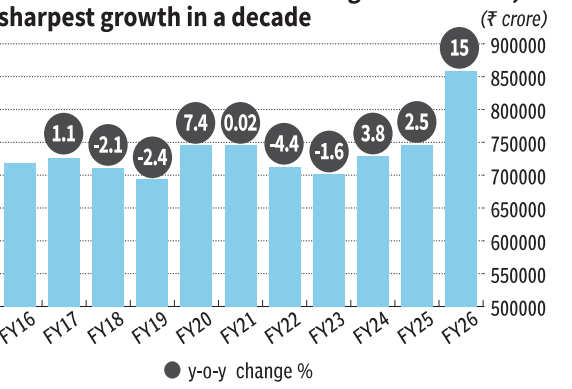
Outstanding education loans from banks rose nearly 15 per cent year-on-year to ₹8.58 lakh crore in FY26 from ₹7.46 lakh crore in FY25, according to data from the Reserve Bank of India’s latest bulletin. The loan book had contracted in FY22 and FY23 before recovering in the last two fiscals.

DEMAND DRIVERS Experts attributed the rise to increasing education costs, rupee depreciation and a growing willingness among families to finance higher education through borrowings. “There’s been a tendency for banks to reach out to more educational institutions, where loans are being provided,” said Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda. He added that lenders were expanding beyond a limited set of institutions and professional courses, as fees rise across the education sector.

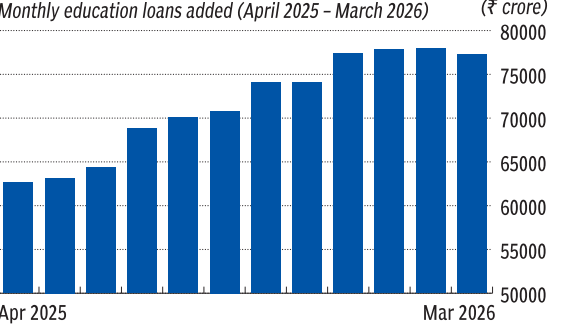
WEAK RUPEE The depreciating rupee has also significantly contributed to loan growth, particularly for overseas education. “The same university, the same course and the same student may now require a larger INR loan simply because the rupee is weaker,” said Sonal Kapoor, Global Chief Business Officer, Prodigy Finance. Ramkumar Subramanian, Partner - Financial Services, Grant Thornton Bharat, said the weaker rupee had pushed families to rely more on external financing as savings

Borrowing to study

Education loans from banks surge 15% in FY26, sharpest growth in a decade



Demand for education loan climbs through FY26



Source: Dbie

increasingly fall short of covering education expenses abroad. While domestic education loans continue to dominate by volume, overseas education loans account for larger ticket sizes. Experts noted that although the US remains the preferred destination for Indian students, countries such as Australia, New Zealand and South Africa are also gaining traction. **SEASONAL DISBURSALS** Monthly data also reflected sustained demand through the year. Education loans added by lenders increased from ₹62,637 crore in April 2025 to ₹77,935 crore in February 2026 before moderating slightly to ₹77,289 crore in March. The sharp rise in education loan additions during the second half of FY26 was largely driven by admission cycles and fee payment schedules. Domestic course fees are generally paid around March-April ahead of the academic year, while international programme disbursements tend to pick up later in the year. **BANKS DOMINATE** Subramanian also mentioned that banks continue to dominate the education loan market with an 80 per cent share, while NBFCs account for the remaining 20 per cent, with some 5 per cent variation. He attributed this to the largely collateralised nature of education loans, unlike unsecured retail lending segments. Sabnavis cautioned that repayment risks remain, particularly if students fail to secure employment after graduation, especially in overseas education loans due to larger borrowing sizes.

EID Parry reports net loss in Q4 due to exceptional charge

Our Bureau
Chennai

Murugappa Group company EID Parry reported a consolidated net loss of ₹287 crore for the quarter ended March 2026 (Q4FY26) compared to a net profit of ₹539 crore in Q4FY25, as exceptional items comprising impairment of assets and restructuring cost of subsidiaries pulled profits down. The consolidated revenue from operations was ₹7,882 crore (₹6,811 crore), largely driven by the sugar business. In Q4FY26, the company in-

Consolidated Q4 scorecard			
	Q4FY26	Q4FY25	₹ crore Growth %
Revenue from operations	7,882	6,811	16
Net profit / (loss)	(-287)	539	NA
Exceptional (charge)/gain	(-478)	347	NA

curring an exceptional charge of ₹478 crore on its profits. This included a ₹138 crore impairment of assets with respect to three cash generating units (CGUs) due to insufficient feedstock availability in Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh. It also included an estimated provision towards impairment of investment/goodwill relat-

ing to the company’s drones subsidiary business, due to a delay in execution of certain orders. On March 31, the EID Parry board approved the closure of operations of subsidiary Parry Sugars Refinery India, and ₹270 crore has been incurred in closure-related costs. For FY26, net profit stood at ₹1,380 crore (₹1,772

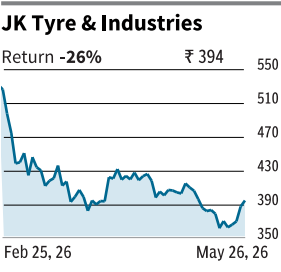
crore). The consolidated revenue for FY26 was ₹38,534 crore (₹31,609 crore). **SUGAR SEGMENT BIZ** Muthiah Murugappan, Whole-time Director and CEO, EID Parry, said that revenues of the sugar segment were at ₹466 crore for Q4FY26 (₹408 crore). “Profit before interest and tax was ₹78 crore (₹56 crore) on account of better realisation and cost optimisation measures,” he added. EID Parry has six sugar factories, having an aggregate capacity to crush 40,800 TCD, generating 140 MW of

power, and five distilleries having a capacity of 582 KLPD. The company also has a significant presence in the farm inputs business through its subsidiary, Coromandel International. In the nutraceuticals business, it holds a strong position in the growing wellness segment, mainly catering to world markets with its organic products. With growth of Parry’s staples business, the company is attempting a transformation from a sugar enterprise into a comprehensive food, nutrition and bioenergy establishment.

JK Tyre to invest ₹4,980 crore for capacity expansion in Chennai, Mysuru plants by 2030

Our Bureau
New Delhi

JK Tyre & Industries (JK Tyre) on Tuesday said its board has approved investment of ₹4,980 crore for capacity expansion of passenger car radials (PCR) and truck/bus radials (TBR) by 2030 in Chennai and Mysuru, through internal accruals and debt. “Looking at the momentary growth and likely demand pick up, our board has approved further expansion of PCR and TBR capacity with an outlay of ₹4,980 crore. This expansion is a proposal to be taken up in three phases – first phase by August 2028 with 50 per cent of the outlay, phase-II by April 2029 with 40 per cent of the total outlay and phase-III by December 2029 with re-



maining 10 per cent,” Raghupati Singhania, Chairman and Managing Director (CMD), JK Tyre, said.

MARKET PRESENCE The company said the Indian tyre industry is witnessing a robust demand across categories, hence the need to maintain market presence through this expansion of 24 per cent more from the current capacity. The board approved the re-appointment of Singhania

The company reported a year-on-year jump of 81.25 per cent in consolidated net profit for the fourth quarter of FY26 to ₹203.14 crore

as the CMD for a term of another five years effective October 1, subject to requisite approval of the members.

ROBUST Q4 Meanwhile, the company reported a year-on-year jump of 81.25 per cent in consolidated net profit for the fourth quarter (Q4) ended March 31 (Q4 FY26) to ₹203.14 crore, compared with ₹112 crore in the corresponding period the previous year. Consolidated total in-

come also rose 12 per cent to ₹4,233 crore (₹3,780 crore). For FY26, the consolidated net profit grew 114 per cent to ₹905 crore (₹422 crore). Total income also grew 11 per cent to ₹16,384 crore (₹14,772 crore). “FY26 has been a landmark year for JK Tyre. We delivered record volumes across segments, attaining the highest-ever annual consolidated revenue of ₹16,384 crore and achieving an EBITDA of ₹2,089 crore, an increase of 25 per cent over the previous year,” Singhania said. He added that the company registered a healthy double-digit growth in revenues, driven by buoyant demand supported by GST and personal tax reforms, softening of interest rates, improved economic activity and the festive season.

TVS Supply Chain bets on India freight rebound, Europe turnaround to drive FY27 growth

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Chennai-based TVS Supply Chain Solutions (TVS SCS) has entered FY27 with growing confidence as strong momentum in India, a turnaround in Europe operations and robust freight-forwarding volumes helped the company navigate global pricing pressures and geopolitical disruptions during the fourth quarter.

Its two core businesses — Integrated Supply Chain Solutions (ISCS) and Global Forwarding Solutions (GFS) — delivered broad-based growth across regions, with the management highlighting improving execution in India, Europe and North America. GFS emerged as the strongest growth driver during Q4, recording a 34.8 per



Ravi Viswanathan, Managing Director, TVS SCS

cent year-on-year rise, led by a sharp recovery in India-driven ocean freight volumes. The performance came despite volatility in global freight rates. Ravi Viswanathan, Managing Director, TVS SCS, said the company remains optimistic about India-led freight demand and expects GFS to perform better in FY27, although pricing pressures continue to persist globally. The company said its US

“It is important to note that the GFS business continues to operate at structurally lower margins and the global freight industry is currently facing uncertainty influenced heavily by war-induced trade disruptions across major trade routes,” he said.

VOLUME GROWTH

While GFS drove volume growth, the ISCS business continued to anchor profitability. ISCS India posted a strong 17.3 per cent growth in Q4, supported by new business-wins and execution momentum. Europe operations also witnessed a significant turnaround, with margin expansion aided by “Project One” cost optimisation initiatives and a better business mix. Sequential growth in ISCS Europe stood at 15.7 per cent. The company said its US

strategy is increasingly focused on deepening relationships with a smaller set of large industrial and automotive customers instead of pursuing broad-based expansion. Viswanathan said the company had delivered over 28 per cent CAGR growth in the US over the past five years through an “account-centric” strategy focused on expanding wallet share with large customers. “Five years ago, the US was really a scattered map. But today, we are getting deeper into fewer customers,” he said. Vikas Chadha, Global Chief Executive Officer, said business development momentum remained strong during FY26. In Q4, we recorded new business wins of ₹523.7 crore, which is an all-time high in a quarter, he said.

Hum Do, Humare Do e-cycles trend catches on across urban India

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

As rising fuel prices squeeze household budgets and short urban commutes become increasingly expensive, consumers are quietly adopting a new mobility strategy: Keep the petrol vehicle for the occasional long trips and shift daily commute to e-cycles. What industry observers are now calling the *Hum Do, Humare Do* e-cycles model is emerging as a pragmatic middle-class response to fuel-cost pressures. Delhi-based Aoki Mobility says inquiries have doubled since the latest fuel price hikes. The broader volumes of organised e-cycle players has already doubled to 60,000-70,000 units a month. Instead of spending ₹1.2-₹1.5 lakh on an e-scooter, many urban households are



GREEN PEDAL. While inquiries have doubled since the latest fuel price hikes, volumes of organised e-cycle players have doubled to 60,000-70,000 units a month

increasingly considering buying two low-speed electric cycles, one for each working member of the family. The price of an e-scooter from a legacy player (such as Bajaj, TVS or Honda) with close to 100 km range is between ₹95,000 and ₹1.25 lakh (ex-showroom), depending on the specific model and battery capacity. The trend gained traction after Aoki Mobility Co-

Founder Diwakar Anupam Mittal said the company had sold over 1,000 units to such couples in recent months in major metros, including Mumbai, Delhi, Ahmedabad and Goa. Mittal said sales at his own operation could touch 7,000-8,000 units a month within the next few months. Organised players such as EMotorad and Hero Lectro are estimated to be doing

brisk sales, with industry volumes potentially crossing one lakh units per month by the year-end if the current momentum sustains. Randheer Singh, Founder and CEO, ForeSee Consulting, said the combination of rising fuel prices, short-distance urban commutes and worsening city congestion is steadily converting e-cycles from niche fitness products into practical “second household mobility assets” designed to reduce monthly fuel expenditure.

THE 250W SWEET SPOT Unlike mainstream e-scooters or cars, low-speed e-cycles, operating below 250 watts and capped at 25 kmph, occupy a unique regulatory sweet spot in India. Entry-level e-cycles are available at roughly ₹25,000-₹45,000, while operating costs for personally-owned vehicles work out to nearly

₹0.07 per km versus around ₹2.50 per km in fuel alone for petrol two-wheelers at current fuel prices. Growth is increasingly concentrated in the ₹30,000-₹55,000 “mass-premium” category, with commercial delivery applications emerging as one of the fastest-growing use-cases. Experts say this is steadily converting from a niche lifestyle product into a utility-first mobility asset. According to them, the next mobility transition may not come from replacing every petrol vehicle with a large EV, but from replacing millions of short petrol-powered trips altogether. Companies such as Yulu, whose fleet of over 45,000 shared EVs has supported over 400 million deliveries, have expanded aggressively into delivery and logistics partnerships as platforms search for lower-cost mobility solutions.

Pocket FM CFO Anurag Sharma steps down

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Audio entertainment platform Pocket FM’s CFO Anurag Sharma has stepped down after nearly five years with the company to pursue his own entrepreneurial journey, according to the company. He was elevated to the position in 2023 before which he was Vice-President, Finance. During his tenure as CFO, he spearheaded the series D funding campaign, which led to \$103 million being raised and led expansion into international markets like the US. Before joining Pocket FM, he was the head of finance at Ninjacart.

With inputs from intern
Vasundhara Prakash

Man Industries Q4 profit down 25% on higher cost

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Man Industries (India), manufacturer of large-diameter carbon steel line pipes and coating systems for the oil and gas sector, reported that its net profit in the March quarter was down 25 per cent to ₹51 crore against ₹68 crore logged in the same period last year, largely due to higher costs. Revenue was down 5 per cent at ₹1,157 crore (₹1,218 crore), while EBITDA increased 8 per cent to ₹148 crore (₹136 crore). In FY26, its net profit was up 11 per cent at ₹170 crore (₹153 crore), while revenue increased marginally to ₹3,564 crore (₹3,505 crore).

FY27 GUIDANCE The company has given a rev-

businessline.
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Flip-flops over Iran

Trump’s Iran ‘deal’ is riddled with uncertainties

Sridhar Krishnaswami

As of now, no one with perhaps the exception of US President Donald Trump knows what the outlines of a deal are with Iran. The chief concern in many quarters is of Washington shifting its focus from Tehran’s nuclear programme to a governing mechanism for the Straits of Hormuz, which was not in the picture at all when Israel and the US started their operations on February 28.

From “imminent” to “in the near future” are the words on the peace deal which has raised the eyebrows of even Trump’s hawkish allies on Capitol Hill and his loyal base.

Gleaning from what has been put out in American media and attributed to ‘officials’ and ‘sources’, Washington and Tehran are on the verge of a breakthrough. The issues are: ending hostilities, the gradual opening of the Strait of Hormuz, unfreezing of Iranian assets and the country allowed to sell its oil, a commitment by Tehran not to pursue nuclear weapons; and talks for handing over some 900 pounds of enriched uranium.

But hardliners in Washington, including on Capitol Hill, are saying that the Trump administration is rushing into a so-called memorandum after initially saying that it had all the time. In other words, Washington is seen as “cutting and running”.

BLURRED OBJECTIVES

The problem for Trump is that he was already under pressure in his party and outside for having gone into Iran with a set of blurred objectives that till date have not been outlined. The Iran operations started with the original purpose of blunting the nuclear weapons programme, but soon got into the regime change mode. And now hardliners, who have never been comfortable with Tehran’s posturing on its nuclear programme, its role in the region or propping up proxies like Hamas, Hezbollah and Houthis, are appalled that the so-called deal leaves the clerics and Ayatollahs and what all they stood for very much in place.

Or as the Chair of the Senate Armed Services Committee, Roger Wicker put it, Trump was being “ill advised to pursue a deal that would not be worth the paper it is written on”, and that “everything accomplished by Operation Epic Fury would be for naught”. And an influential



TRUMP. Confused signals REUTERS

Republican Senator Lindsey Graham argued that a precedent of Iran controlling the Hormuz and threatening the oil infrastructure of the neighbours is “a major shift of the balance of power in the region and overtime will be a nightmare for Israel”.

The Netanyahu government has been maintaining a studied silence on the future of Iran’s nuclear weapons programme — with speculation over whether Tehran will fully abandon or postpone it for a period of between five and 20 years; and on the fate of the remaining enriched uranium. Earlier, there was the impression that the uranium stockpile will be transferred to the US; now there are questions as to whether it will be with Iran or in a third country like Russia.

Now, adding to the existing confusion is Trump maintaining that Muslim nations like Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Pakistan, Turkey, Egypt and Jordan should join the Abraham Accords and normalise relations with Israel as he negotiates an accord to end the war with Iran. The UAE and Bahrain have already signed the 2020 Accords. Turkey, Egypt and Jordan have relations with Israel; but many Arab nations, especially Saudi Arabia, are saying that the Abraham Accords do not have a roadmap for Palestinian statehood. Pakistan is said to have rejected the proposal. And Tel Aviv is yet to make an official response.

“Trump is trying to sell an Iran deal as an Abraham Accords sequel: good for Israel, good for the region, tough enough for Washington. But he is trading one fantasy for another — from forcing Iran to surrender to pretending a fragile deal can anchor a new Middle East order”, Ali Vaez, Iran project director of the International Crisis Group has been quoted.

The writer is a senior journalist who has reported from Washington DC on North America and UN

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

May 27, 2006

IPO scam: SEBI bars Karvy group entities

SEBI on Friday barred Karvy group entities from carrying on several of its businesses including depository participant, share registrar and proprietary trading with immediate effect for its role in the IPO scam. In its order issued late Friday, SEBI barred Karvy’s stock broking subsidiary Karvy Stock Broking Ltd (KSBL) from taking fresh DP business.

S&P looking at equity research on Indian companies

Standard & Poor’s, a global provider of independent rating of investment risks, is contemplating entering India with its equity research products, Ms Lorraine Tan, Vice-President Equity Research, Asia Pacific of S&P, told Business Line here today.

Left to examine Govt’s divestment programme

The four Left parties extending outside support to the UPA Government are likely to meet next Thursday to review the Government’s stand on airport modernisation, disinvestment, oil price hikes and reservations in educational institutions. The move assumes significance with the Government renewing its plans to move ahead with its disinvestment programme of profitable PSUs.

Countering resource nationalism

Indonesia’s move to channelise coal exports through a state entity must make India calibrate its energy strategy

CAPITAL IDEAS.



RICHA MISHRA

The current geopolitical uncertainty has triggered an energy market disruption that is benefiting coal. No surprises then that the major coal exporting nations are aggressively leveraging the current crisis to maximise revenue, capture market share, and more importantly dictate trade terms, as the Asian and European utilities swivel away from expensive, bottlenecked natural gas.

Indonesia’s move to “nationalise coal export activity” has caught media attention. According to reports, Jakarta is moving to become the single selling point for Indonesia’s thermal coal exports. If and when implemented this would end the current mechanism of international buyers negotiating directly with the miners and traders in that country.

It aims to centralise exports of natural resources, including coal, crude palm oil and nickel ferro alloys. According to reports, all Indonesian coal exports to foreign buyers will be handled by a single state-owned enterprise (SOE).

Should Indian players worry about this move?

Historically, Indian power plants and traders have negotiated directly with private Indonesian miners to secure low-cost, low-ash thermal coal. Reports last week said, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto has said that his government will mandate that exports of palm oil, coal, and ferroalloys be conducted through a state agency, as the country seeks to tighten its control over its natural resources and boost state revenue.

Though Indonesia is among the largest suppliers of thermal coal to India, Jakarta’s plans will not fructify overnight. To minimise an immediate trade freeze, the Indonesian government has structured a strict, highly compressed three-month transition window, according to reports.



ENERGY SECURITY. India must work towards ramping up domestic coal production

India relies on Indonesia to sustain its grid and vital industrial sectors, making the volume, quality, and logistics of this trade highly critical. Unlike Australia, which sells premium coking coal for Indian steelmaking, Indonesia exports low-to-medium calorific value non-coking coal. This is used exclusively for electricity generation in Thermal Power Plants (TPPs) and kiln-firing in cement factories. Several coastal Indian power plants are designed and configured specifically to run on imported coal mixtures.

The Power Ministry routinely mandates utilities to import coal for blending up to 10 per cent of their total fuel mix to safeguard against domestic mine flooding during monsoon seasons.

INDIA’S MOVES

India must maximise domestic alternatives and widen its supplier base to shield itself from potential Indonesian supply chain shocks, price floor enforcement, and newly proposed

Historically, Indian power plants and traders have negotiated directly with private Indonesian miners to secure low-cost, low-ash thermal coal

export tariffs. India has successfully pushed its domestic coal production over 1 billion tonnes. Coal India Ltd (CIL) is actively working to displace imported thermal volumes by flooding local auctions and expanding production pathways.

According to Tracy Shuchart, Senior Economist, NinjaTrader Group, LLC, “India is less exposed to this than the topline numbers suggest.”

According to Coal Ministry data, total coal imports fell 7.9 per cent in FY25 to 243.62 million tonnes, saving roughly \$7.93 billion in foreign exchange. “The number that matters most for the Indonesian story is buried inside that release.

Coal imports for blending by thermal power plants dropped 41.4 per cent year-on-year in FY25 even as coal-based power generation grew 3 per cent. That is the precise demand category Indonesian low CV coal serves, and India already cut it by more than 40 per cent in a single year,” she pointed out.

Domestic production crossed 1 billion tonnes in FY25 and the government’s stated target is zero substitutable coal imports by FY26. “On supplier mix, Bancosta vessel data shows Indonesia’s share of India’s seaborne imports fell from roughly 60 per cent in 2024 to 40.3 per cent in the first nine months of 2025, with Russian and South African cargoes hitting record highs to replace Indonesian volumes,”

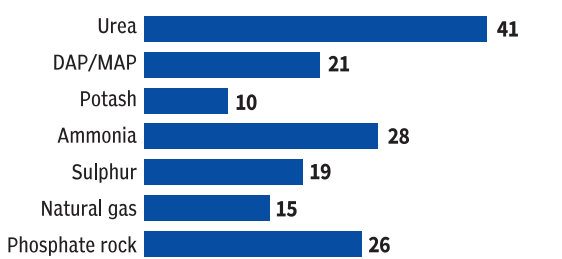
STATISTALK.

Compiled by Vasupradha Sandeep, intern | Graphic KS Gunasekar

Ripple effects of the Iran conflict on the fertilizer market

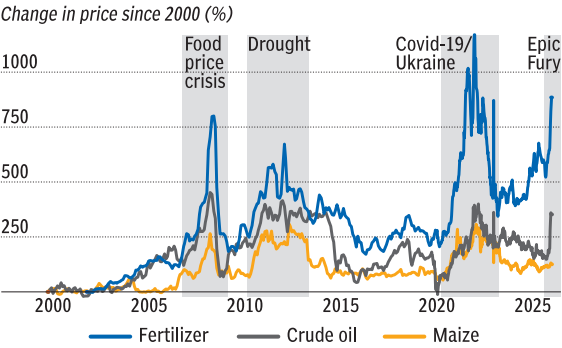
Nearly one-third of globally traded fertilizer passes through the Strait of Hormuz. Its closure therefore, cut fertilizer flows to the extent of 87 per cent of the pre-conflict average. This caused prices to skyrocket, with key inputs like urea being currently priced at \$850/tonne compared to about \$450/tonne in February. This is exacerbated by dwindling LNG imports forcing domestic fertilizer production to shut down. Historically, agricultural commodity prices have shown inflationary trends during crises, with rising fertilizer prices often pushing up food prices. The brunt of this will be felt more by the Gulf fertilizer-dependent countries

Global fertilizer, feedstock exports originating from West Asia



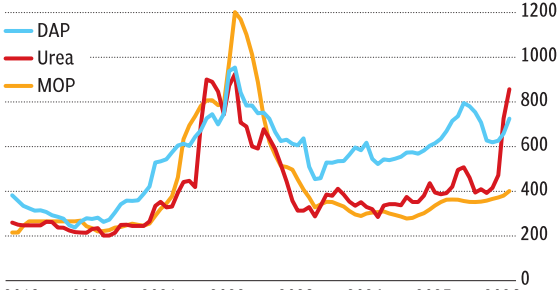
DAP = diammonium phosphate, MAP = monoammonium phosphate
Based on 2024 data

Fertilizers, food inflate when oil price spikes



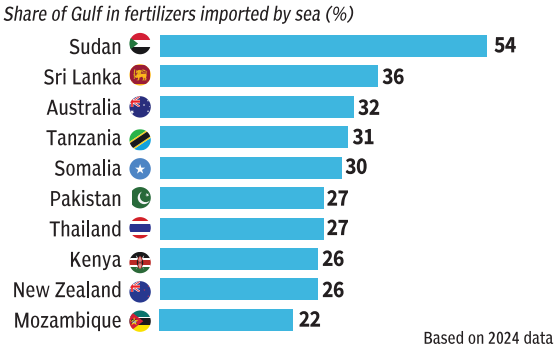
Source: S&P Global, The Energy Institute, International Fertilizer Association, World Bank, FAO, Center for Strategic and International Studies, UNCTAD

Fertilizer prices shoot up



Note: DAP = diammonium phosphate; MOP = muriate of potassium; mt = metric tonnes. Monthly series. Last observation is April 2026

Countries vulnerable to paucity of Gulf fertilizers



Based on 2024 data

Shuchart said. The government must be credited for working towards a policy to safeguard against such policy disruptions.

“If Jakarta’s single SOE model creates supply disruption or enforces price floors above market, India accelerates a substitution already well underway. The buyers genuinely cornered by this policy are the Philippines and Bangladesh, where Indonesian dependency runs much deeper,” she said.

The proposed move by Indonesia reflects a growing trend of resource nationalism across commodity-exporting economies, where governments are seeking greater control over pricing, revenues, and strategic natural resources.

Mexico and Chile are tightening state control over lithium, and oil-producing nations are using state entities to influence hydrocarbon production and pricing.

Energy and mineral resources are increasingly being viewed not just as commercial commodities, but as strategic national assets linked to economic security and geopolitical influence.

This may improve tax revenues and national bargaining power, but it also creates execution risk, say critics. The success of this policy will depend on whether it can be implemented without disrupting shipments, politicising allocations, scaring buyers, and making coal pricing less transparent.

The Coal Ministry estimates that overall domestic coal demand will scale up to 1.5 billion tonnes by 2029-30. Major Indian buyers of Indonesian coal are divided into two groups: conglomerate power producers that burn the coal directly in their coastal mega-plants, and specialised commodity trading firms that import the coal in bulk to distribute to mid-sized domestic industries.

Indian procurement strategies will have to pivot heavily toward alternative origins, such as Australia or South Africa, or sharply accelerate domestic coal production.

India’s push to reduce dependence on imported coal to strengthen energy security is also crucial.

On businessline.in

The policy pivot Trump needs

There are better ways to help US manufacturing and its left-behind workers than through a weaker dollar alone, says **Glenn Hubbard**
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www.project-syndicate.org
https://tinyurl.com/uxjxhvh

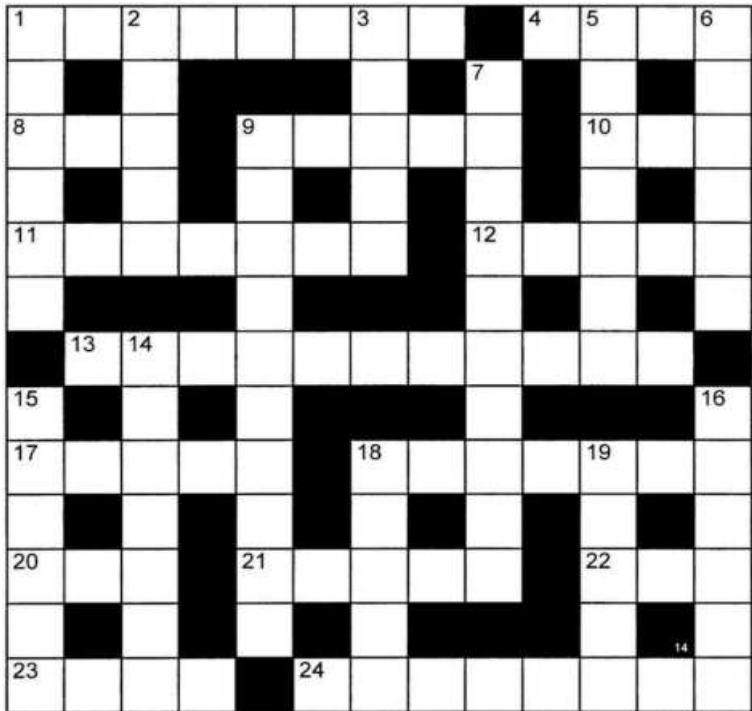
The cost-per-fisher case India has not yet made

India holds the strongest developing-country argument on fisheries subsidies — and the weakest procedural record in advancing, say **Siddhartha K Rastogi** and **Chaitanya Khurana**
https://tinyurl.com/2e53zphr

Farewell to investment fluctuation reserve

Its scrapping was not surprising given the operational challenges it posed to banks. But with rising G-Sec yields the abolition could have been gradual, argues **Manas R Das**
https://tinyurl.com/3e6kndpj

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2688



EASY

ACROSS

- Part of church building (8)
- Dirty talk (4)
- Emmet (3)
- Suspension of hostilities (5)
- In tennis, a let (3)
- Story told to point moral (7)
- Censure (5)
- Large self-service retail store (11)
- ____-plane shutter, camera ‘blind’ (5)
- Accomplish, win (7)
- Look at (3)
- Card of taking suit (5)
- Point gun at (3)
- Unenlightened (4)
- Lees (8)

DOWN

- Hoboes (6)
- Make different (5)
- Wait momentarily (5)
- A composite of superimposed pictures (7)
- To reel, stagger (6)
- Fact of belonging to club (10)
- Linen cover used at meal-times (10)
- Not readily understandable (7)
- Displease, make angry (6)
- Allow (6)
- To tickle (5)
- Rub out (5)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Patterns worked out crossing the nave (8)
- Speck of soot not talked of in polite company (4)
- A worker or soldier in human terms (3)
- No more fighting for the Sappers : cut it out! (5)
- A snare of machine-made lace (3)
- Story with a moral backing in hotel bar, apparently (7)
- Find fault with the way Mabel put it (5)
- Large store can make up rest, right? (11)
- Sort of point that may be sharply defined (5)
- Ache I’ve got to bring it to a successful conclusion (7)
- It can observe a spring of water (3)
- Take a trick up to make a false charge (5)
- One’s object is to be one in a thousand (3)
- The theatre’s closed, so keep it secret (4)
- Men’s diet may be composed of the dregs (8)

DOWN

- Takes to the road with the cargo-steamers (6)
- Change the rate in which pound is held (5)
- Wait a while and tumultuous sea will get up (5)
- Composite picture in mat gone wrong (7)
- Stagger along like a retriever of rubbish (6)
- Fact of belonging to a politician’s joint (10)
- Lay it between plate and board (10)
- It’s not obvious that pawnbroker has a right to it (7)
- It may hurt one’s feelings to break the law (6)
- It allows one to give instruction to hairdresser (6)
- A goddess such as Clio to keep one entertained (5)
- If it turns up in one’s area, wipe it out (5)

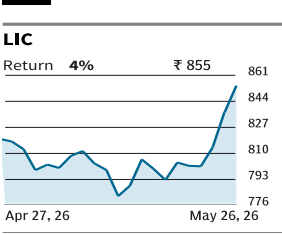
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2687

ACROSS 1. Cormorant 5. Cab 7. Iris 8. Attitude 10. Precious 11. Pink 13. Rebuff 15. Stench 18. Post 19. Corridor 22. Laudable 23. Pole 24. Tot 25. Permanent

DOWN 1. Clipper 2. Raise 3. Artful 4. Thin 5. Caution 6. Break 9. Jiffy 12. Stark 14. Biscuit 16. Harvest 17. Boiler 18. Pilot 20. Drone 21. Lamp

QUICKLY.

LIC rallies on 1:1 bonus issue; May 29 record date



Bengaluru: Shares of Life Insurance Corporation of India settled nearly 2 per cent higher on Tuesday. The state-run insurer recently announced its first-ever bonus share issue since listing on the stock exchanges. Investor sentiment improved after the 1:1 bonus share issue, under which shareholders will receive one additional fully paid-up share for every existing share held. Market participants said the move is likely to improve liquidity in the counter and make the stock more affordable for retail investors. The issue will be financed by capitalising ₹6,325 crore from the insurer's accumulated reserves. LIC has fixed May 29 as the record date for determining shareholder eligibility for the bonus shares. **OUR BUREAU**

Hexagon sets IPO price band at ₹42-45/share

New Delhi: Hexagon Nutrition, a pure-play nutrition company, has fixed a price band of ₹42-45 per share for its ₹139-crore initial public offering (IPO), which will open for subscription on June 5. The public issue will conclude on June 9, while the bidding for anchor investors will open for a day on June 4, according to the red herring prospectus. The proposed IPO of the Mumbai-based company is entirely an offer-for-sale of more than 3.08 crore shares by promoters. Founded in 1993, Hexagon Nutrition began operations as a micro-nutrient formulations player and later expanded into branded nutrition products. **PM**

‘Renewable energy project awarded to SPV of InvIT via bid is a PPP’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has clarified that a renewable energy (RE) project awarded by a public sector or government entity to a special purpose vehicle (SPV) of an infrastructure investment trust (InvIT) through competitive bidding is considered a public private partnership project (PPP). The clarification by the capital markets regulator is in response to a query on RE assets, which are obtained through tariff based competitive bidding or any other competitive bidding mechanism with government entities as offtakers, should be considered as PPP Projects. “Without necessarily agreeing with your analysis, you may note that a project for generation and supply of RE, awarded by a public sector entity/government entity to a SPV of an InvIT, which is selected on the basis of open competitive bidding or on

Pine Labs slides 8% as Q4 results miss estimates

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of Pine Labs ended down 8.26 per cent at ₹137.94 on the NSE, after the fintech company's Q4 FY26 results disappointed street estimates. The stock hit an intra-day high of ₹152.80 before selling pressure pushed it to the day's low of ₹135.52. Morgan Stanley maintained its 'Equal-weight' rating with a target price of ₹245, noting Q4 revenue growth of 17 per cent y-o-y missed consensus by around 3 per cent, while adjusted EBITDA of ₹146 crore came in slightly below expectations. Pine Labs reported FY26 revenue of ₹2,711 crore, up 19 per cent y-o-y, with adjusted EBITDA of ₹559 crore, up 57 per cent.

SEBI mulls tokenisation model to deepen corporate bond market

ON AGENDA. Regulator contemplating bond ETFs, market reforms, easier norms for debt-only listed entities

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India is planning a pilot project for tokenisation of corporate bonds using distributed ledger technology (DLT) as part of a broader push to deepen India's corporate debt market. Speaking at the CareEdge Debt Summit on Tuesday, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said the regulator is exploring whether tokenisation can help deliver “faster settlement, better traceability, automated servicing, and greater transparency” in the bond market. DLT is already in use by depositories for governance, management and monitoring purposes. SEBI is now examining whether the technology can be used to make cor-

porate bond settlements more efficient. The pilot project could be implemented over the next six to nine months, he said. “This is basically instantaneous settlement with all the benefits of tokenisation,” he said.

MARKET LIQUIDITY

The market regulator is also working with market participants, RBI and the Finance Ministry to operationalise the market-making framework announced in the Budget. SEBI is additionally looking at developing bond exchange traded funds and derivatives on corporate bond indices to improve liquidity and allow retail investors to access debt markets with smaller ticket sizes. Pandey said corporate bond index derivatives could be launched after the RBI approves draft guidelines is-



PILOT PROJECT. SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey, at the CareEdge Debt Summit on Tuesday, said it is exploring whether tokenisation can help in faster settlement in bond market **ANI**

sued earlier this year. SEBI is also examining a separate regulatory classification for debt brokers to lower costs and reduce entry barriers for intermediaries focused only on debt markets. The corporate bond market has expanded significantly over the years, but several structural gaps remain, he said. Outstanding corporate bonds have risen from

around ₹17.5 lakh crore at the end of FY15 to over ₹59 lakh crore, while debt issuances in FY26 mobilised ₹9.1 lakh crore, nearly double the amount raised through equity markets.

ISSUER BASE

However, the market remains concentrated, with nearly 85-90 per cent of issuances rated AA or AAA and

around 70 per cent of outstanding bonds belonging to financial sector entities. “The issuer base is narrow. Around 6,000 companies are listed on NSE and BSE, but only 776 have listed debt,” he said. Low retail participation is a key concern, he said. Awareness of corporate bonds stands at only 10 per cent, while household penetration remains below 1 per cent, according to a SEBI survey. “Retail participation will not grow merely because products are available. It will grow when products are understood,” he said, adding that SEBI will conduct bond-focused investor awareness campaigns under ‘Project Jagrook’. SEBI will also undertake issuer outreach programmes focused on SMEs and companies that are ready for listing in debt markets.

Union Bank to raise ₹8,000 cr through debt, equity mix

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Union Bank of India on Tuesday approved raising of up to ₹8,000 crore, which would include the issuance of equities worth ₹3,000 crore. In a BSE filing, Union Bank said its board had approved raising of debt capital through Basel III-compliant additional tier-1 bonds and/or tier-2 not exceeding ₹5,000 crore. Besides, the board approved raising ₹3,000 crore equity capital in tranches within the overall limit of ₹8,000 crore, through a public issue.

Nifty, Sensex tumble even as Mid-cap scales new peak

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Broader markets stole the limelight on Tuesday even as the benchmark indices faced headwinds. The Nifty Mid-cap100, in fact, hit fresh all time high at 62365.25 even as Taiwan displaced India from fifth spot in market capitalisation. The Sensex closed 479 points lower at 76,009.70, while the Nifty fell 118 points to 23,913.70, slipping back below the 24,000 mark it had reclaimed just the previous session. The Nifty Midcap 100 index closed 0.54 per cent higher at 62,299 and the Smallcap 100 advanced 0.4 per cent.

TAIWAN SURGES AHEAD

According to Bloomberg data, Taiwan with a market-cap of \$4.95 trillion replaced India (\$4.92 trillion) at fifth spot, behind US, China, Japan and Hong Kong. Chip maker Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co led the rally for Taiwan. Markets were also volatile due to two successive settlement days for monthly contracts on the NSE and BSE. While May contracts on the NSE expired on Tuesday, on the BSE, they will expire on Wednesday.

“The news of renewed US military action in the Middle East dampened hopes of an immediate US-Iran peace agreement, thereby weighing on market sentiment and pushing Brent crude prices back toward the \$98 per barrel mark,” said Ajit Mishra, SVP-Research at Religare Broking. Despite volatility in front-line indices, the Nifty Mid-cap100 index surged to a fresh all-time high, supported by growth-oriented stocks such as Adani Total Gas, Exide Industries,



Naukri, KPIT and JSW Energy, said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd. “The resilience in broader markets despite prevailing global uncertainties reflects sustained domestic liquidity participation,” he added. Sudeep Shah, Head of Technical and Derivatives Research at SBI Securities, pointed out that the ratio charts of both Midcap and Smallcap indices relative to the Nifty continue to trend higher, confirming structural outperformance. The Midcap 100's price-to-earnings ratio stands at 29.94 and price-to-book at 4.88. The index is up 9.17 per cent over the past year and 143.68 per cent over five year period.

METAL STOCKS SHINE

Sectorally, the session had a clear split. Metal stocks, supported by rising global commodity prices in aluminium, copper, and zinc, emerged as the standout outperformers, with the Nifty Metal index gaining over 1.2 per cent. Stocks including Hindalco, Vedanta, and Lloyds Metals drew institutional interest. Nifty Energy also closed in positive territory. Banking was the weakest link, with private lenders such as Axis Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank, as well as PSU bank counters, all under pressure from expiry-related selling and tightening liquidity concerns. Consumer Durables and Realty also ended in the red.

BROKER'S CALL.

Choice International

JK CEMENT (BUY)
Target: ₹7,000
CMP: ₹5,311.30
JK Cement reported Q4FY26 consolidated revenue and EBITDA of ₹3,887.5 crore (+8.6 per cent year on year) and ₹682.5 crore (-10.8 per cent) vs CIE estimate of ₹4,010.4 crore and ₹690.1 crore, respectively. The management has guided FY27E capex at ₹3,000-4,000 crore, followed by ₹1,500-2,000 crore in FY28E, reflecting continued focus on capacity expansion and operational strengthening. The company expects strong double-digit growth in grey cement volumes in FY27E. The management indicated that Q1FY27 profitability is likely to remain broadly in line with the Q4FY26 level. However, the margin in Q2FY27 could face pressure if cement price hikes are insufficient to fully offset the potential increase in diesel cost. Fuel cost is likely to rise by nearly ₹150-200/tonne, although the management indicated that the situation remains dynamic, with fuel orders secured until September. The management increased the price of white cement and wall putty to offset the higher input cost, particularly the sharp rise in chemical prices. However, the possibility of passing on any further diesel-led cost inflation remains uncertain. We maintain our Buy rating on JK Cement while revising our target price downwards to ₹7,000/share. We anticipate EBITDA to expand at a CAGR of 16.8 per cent over FY26-29E, driven by healthy volume growth and realisation growth. We derive our one-year forward target price by assigning an EV/CE multiple of 3.5x to FY28E estimates.

Geojit Financial

CG POWER AND IND (BUY)
Target: ₹968
CMP: ₹879.20
CG Power and Industrial Solutions (CG Power) develops and distributes electrical equipment such as transformers, reactors and other control equipment, and also manufactures industrial motors and pumps and communication systems. Its consolidated revenue grew 25 per cent to ₹3,442 crore in Q4FY26. Revenue in the power systems segment grew 49.7 per cent to ₹1,487 crore, supported by a strong demand momentum and execution discipline, leading to higher project deliveries. Industrial systems revenue rose 2.3 per cent to ₹1,791 crore, led by growth in motors/drives, partly offset by intense competition and a higher proportion of lower-margin railways orders. EBITDA rose 30 per cent to ₹544 crore and margin improved 60 bps to 15.8 per cent. Reported profit after tax increased 31.8 per cent to ₹36 crore, supported by higher revenue and improved operating leverage. Power systems continues to lead the overall performance on the back of robust execution and sustained domestic and global demand for transformers/switchgear, with the order-book remaining strong, aided by large utility and export-wins. Industrial systems performance is expected to improve gradually, supported by traction in the motors business (benefiting from pricing discipline) and better execution in railways. Therefore, we upgrade our rating to BUY from HOLD with a forward-target price of ₹968, implying a valuation of 72.0x FY28E adjusted EPS.

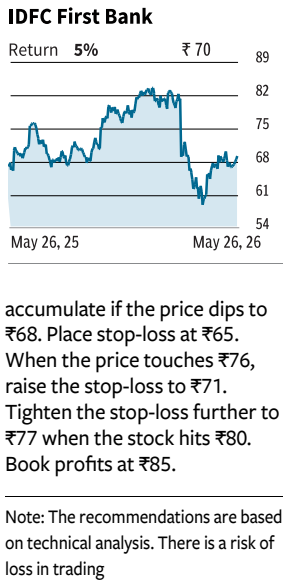
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY'S PICK.

IDFC First Bank (₹70.23): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of IDFC First Bank has been rallying since early April. After witnessing some temporary moderation in price recently, the price action shows that the stock is resuming its upward movement. This week, the price has risen above a key level of ₹69 and also above the 21-day moving average, indicating bullishness. Going ahead, we expect the rally to gain further momentum, potentially lifting the stock to ₹85 in the near-term. Therefore, participants can consider buying the stock of IDFC First Bank at ₹70 and



accumulate if the price dips to ₹68. Place stop-loss at ₹65. When the price touches ₹76, raise the stop-loss to ₹71. Tighten the stop-loss further to ₹77 when the stock hits ₹80. Book profits at ₹85. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23995 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23900	23750	24150	24300	Contract is likely to rally; go long with a stop-loss at 23880.

₹779 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
778	756	800	815	Stock is at a support; go long now with a stop-loss at 765.

₹1167 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1160	1140	1190	1200	Likely to see a recovery; buy now with a stop-loss at 1140.

₹301 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
300	290	307	312	Hovering near a support; buy now with a stop-loss at 295.

₹287 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
284	279	290	295	Stock shows weakness; initiate short with stop-loss at 290.

₹1356 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1350	1325	1375	1400	Go long if the stock breaks out of 1375; stop-loss at 1355.

₹968 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
962	950	978	990	Looks set to rally; go long now and place a stop-loss at 950.

₹2276 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2255	2215	2330	2380	The intraday trend appears uncertain; refrain from trading.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers ▼ 118.00 pts.					
	Close(T)	Pts	PE	WN%	
Adani Enter	2969.30	7.47	38.55	0.78	
Tata Motors PV	385.60	5.64	4733.40	0.74	
Eterna Ltd	250.17	3.93	659.63	1.64	
Tech Mahindra	1458.70	3.21	29.74	0.94	
Hind Unilever	2209.40	2.50	49.06	1.07	
Bajaj Auto	10593.00	2.46	28.00	1.79	
NestleIndia	1428.60	2.34	78.73	0.93	
ONGC	287.50	2.16	8.04	1.02	
Adani Ports	1811.20	1.34	32.65	1.22	
Hindalco	1103.80	1.33	18.52	1.46	
L&T	4037.80	1.13	29.31	4.32	
Maruti Suzuki	13208.00	1.09	28.29	1.58	
JSW Steel	1293.60	0.86	12.40	1.11	
Tata Steel	210.47	0.45	24.14	1.59	
Cipla	1417.50	0.44	29.65	0.73	
Coal India	458.15	0.07	9.09	0.95	
TataConsumerProduct	993.35	-1.12	37.12	1.80	
Sun Pharma	1840.80	0.05	38.38	1.78	
HDFC Life	618.85	-0.27	69.82	0.61	
NTPC	389.70	-0.36	13.72	1.68	
Dr Reddys Lab	1327.90	-0.47	26.66	0.74	
Grasim Ind	3165.00	-0.55	20.91	1.10	
Infosys	1167.70	-0.61	16.07	3.73	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	240.67	-0.77	97.96	0.72	
Bajaj Finserv	1800.70	-0.84	14.65	0.95	
HCL Tech	1161.90	-0.87	18.93	1.12	
State Bank	966.10	-1.00	10.32	3.66	
Int'lBolsAvi	4480.80	-1.04	53.95	0.92	
Asian Paints	2647.00	-1.06	64.94	1.09	
Max Healthcare	993.35	-1.12	37.12	1.80	
Eicher Motors	7376.00	-1.14	36.69	0.93	
Bharat Elec	420.10	-1.37	50.66	1.37	
SBI Life	1883.20	-1.83	76.46	0.77	
Wipro	203.73	-1.94	16.11	0.53	
UltraTech Cement	11623.00	-2.66	41.83	1.25	
PowerGrid Corp	292.30	-2.77	17.08	1.22	
Trent Ltd	4239.60	-2.92	87.56	0.86	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	952.15	-2.99	22.35	1.22	
Apollo Hosp	8258.50	-3.26	59.30	0.77	
Titan	4105.90	-4.80	71.84	1.54	
ITC	301.65	-4.83	17.98	2.65	
M&M	3307.30	-4.18	20.75	2.53	
Kotak Bank	388.65	-6.74	20.04	2.61	
Bajaj Finance	930.20	-6.82	29.94	2.27	
TCS	2276.20	-7.13	16.65	2.12	
Axis Bank	1299.30	-7.44	15.21	3.40	
Reliance Ind	1356.30	-15.76	19.17	8.35	
Bharti Airtel	1846.90	-18.67	33.27	5.17	
ICICI Bank	1279.10	-45.80	53.81	8.54	
HDFC Bank	778.90	-26.53	15.13	10.87	

Nifty Next 50 Movers ▲ 129.25 pts.					
	Close(T)	Pts	PE	WN%	
Adani Power	244.53	130.19	36.36	4.02	
Vedanta	344.90	59.48	8.50	2.33	
Adani Energy Solutions	1463.30	57.78	73.47	2.02	
AdaniGreenenergy	1457.40	43.82	120.82	1.94	
Tata Power	420.95	34.97	26.28	2.80	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	879.15	21.79	115.70	2.40	
Hindus Zinc	647.40	15.79	19.78	1.12	
Cummins India	5418.50	13.92	67.00	2.91	
Ambuja Cements	449.70	13.34	20.22	1.09	
Godrej Consumer	10331.80	12.95	56.72	1.85	
Jindal Steel	1222.90	11.08	37.12	1.80	
Tata Capital	317.00	9.08	27.51	0.54	
United Spirits	1293.40	7.75	50.39	1.52	
Bajaj Holdings	10705.00	7.70	12.17	1.84	
Abb India	6804.00	7.26	91.25	1.42	
Solar Industries	18479.00	7.01	96.29	1.79	
ZyklusSciences	1079.05	4.31	21.19	1.01	
Britannia Ind	5338.00	3.66	50.68	2.50	
Avenuesuper	4103.60	2.66	89.91	2.40	
Siemens	3677.20	2.42	82.59	1.29	
Varun Beverages	531.30	2.32	55.99	2.89	
Hyundai Motor India	1884.00	1.25	28.18	1.07	
Pillitind	1478.50	1.14	60.90	1.82	
Hindustanaeronautics	4427.70	0.96	32.48	3.34	
SamvardmotherInternat	135.82	-1.12	35.09	2.39	
Divis Lab	6753.00	-1.26	69.81	3.41	
Mazagon Dock	2460.10	-2.17	36.01	0.74	
Macrotech Developers	903.70	-2.50	26.31	1.01	
Punjab Natl Bank	105.91	-3.41	6.59	1.45	
DFI	589.80	-4.53	33.81	1.51	
Canara Bank	133.15	-5.23	6.76	1.79	
Ltimindtree	3970.40	-5.55	23.63	1.47	
Shree Cement	25180.00	-6.61	51.95	1.34	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	99.28	-6.64	18.51	0.79	
MuthootFin	3331.50	-6.93	12.61	1.42	
Boch	35835.00	-11.63	38.11	1.24	
Indian Hotels Co.	657.15	-16.86	41.62	2.30	
Rural Elec	337.60	-16.82	5.45	1.68	
Indian Oilcorp	142.38	-16.56	4.60	2.12	
Bpcl	304.60	-20.88	5.11	2.46	
Power Finance	433.70	-21.37	4.26	2.51	
Siemens Energy India	3462.60	-24.22	94.14	1.22	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1567.30	-28.65	25.52	2.67	

CM
YK

QUICKLY.

Gold falls on bets of higher US interest rates



Gold fell more than 1 per cent on Tuesday on bets of higher US interest rates this year, with the military strikes on Iran dialling back hopes of a peace deal, elevating oil prices and bringing inflation concerns to the forefront. Spot gold was down 1 per cent at \$4,526.86 per ounce as of 9.25 am EDT. US gold futures for June delivery rose 0.1 per cent to \$4,527.90. REUTERS

Supply worries push aluminium to 4-year high

London: Aluminium prices hit their highest in more than four years on Tuesday, as rising prices for the feedstock alumina added to persistent concerns about a tightening market amid reduced supply from Gulf producers. Three-month aluminium on the London Metal Exchange rose 0.8 per cent to \$3,680 in official open-outcry trading after hitting \$3,707.5, the highest since March 24, 2022. REUTERS

Crude oil rebounds as US, Iran escalate tensions

Oil rebounded as fresh clashes between the US and Iran clouded the outlook for an interim deal to reopen the vital Strait of Hormuz. Global benchmark Brent rose toward \$99 a barrel after slumping more than 7 per cent on Monday. The US military said it targeted missile-launch sites in southern Iran and boats attempting to lay mines, while the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said it fired at an F-35 fighter jet and several drones after they entered Iranian airspace. BLOOMBERG

Brewing storm over Bay delays onset of monsoon over Kerala coast

DRY INTERLUDE. Monsoon slows as MJO pulse carrying clouds and moisture exits Indian Ocean for now

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

The incoming South-West monsoon continues to linger along the Sri Lankan latitudes, still deprived of the sea-borne circulation that would normally propel it northward into Kerala.

Such a ‘vortex’ now appears unlikely to form before the month-end, delaying the season’s decisive advance into mainland India.

This is in contrast to the India Meteorological Department’s (IMD) earlier projection of the South-West monsoon emerging on May 26, six days before the usual schedule of June 1.

NO MJO SUPPORT

Nor is there support forthcoming from the upper atmosphere. The Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO), an

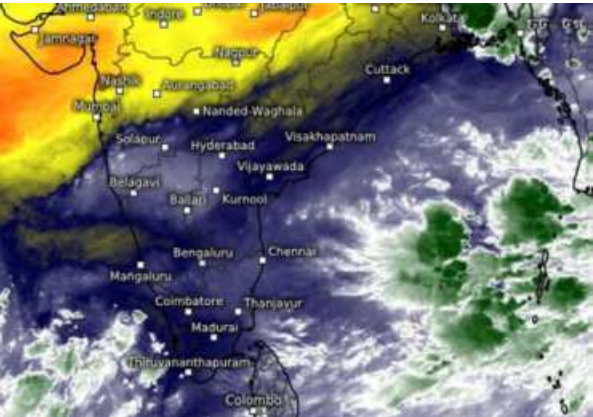
eastward-moving tropical pulse that often shepherds monsoon onsets, has already moved out of the Indian Ocean into the western Pacific. Current global projections suggest it may not return until around June 18.

This roaming equatorial wave of clouds and rainfall, recurring every 30 to 60 days, is closely linked to the birth of tropical storms and strengthening of the monsoon current and its onset under its footprint. Its absence has left the Arabian Sea branch of the monsoon without its usual atmospheric momentum.

CLASSICAL ONSET

The IMD model guidance now suggests that conditions for a classical monsoon onset are unlikely to fall into place before June 5.

The delay stems largely from disrupted upper-level



CLOUD SHIFT. Clouds are not exactly filling the Kerala coast while a group (in dark green) is headed to the east Bay of Bengal where a low-pressure area may form soon

winds, influenced by a developing storm system over the east Bay of Bengal, though the IMD has not said this in as many words.

That storm is expected to move towards the Myanmar-Bangladesh coast. Once

it clears the region, monsoon flows trailing behind it should gradually settle into a more organised pattern along the Kerala coast.

The IMD outlook is broadly echoed by the European Centre for Me-

dium-Range Weather Forecasts (ECMWF), which projects a spell of rain across Kerala, coastal Karnataka, parts of coastal Tamil Nadu and the south Andhra Pradesh coast between June 1 and 8.

HEADED AWAY

In the following week, from June 8-15, rainfall is expected to expand northward along the east coast from Andhra Pradesh towards Odisha and West Bengal, likely under the influence of the Bay system, while Tamil Nadu may begin to dry out, according to the ECMWF.

Yet the longer-range outlook hints at a familiar monsoon hesitation; from mid-June onward, rain could retreat even from regions that first received the onset spell, including Kerala, signalling a premature weakening of the initial advance.

Area under summer crops up 3%, but paddy, moong acreage dips

Summer crops acreage (lakh hectare)			
	2025*	2026*	% change
Paddy	28.65	27.86	-2.8
Pulses	3.47	4.09	17.9
Moong	2.18	2.57	17.9
Urad	1.14	1.28	12.3
Nutri/Coarse cereals	6.84	6.04	-11.7
Bajra	1.35	1.38	2.2
Maize	5.00	4.24	-15.2
Oilseeds	4.73	4.69	-0.8
Groundnut	2.97	2.98	0.3
Sesamum	1.42	1.35	-4.9
All crops	43.69	42.68	-2.3

*As of March 20, Source: Agriculture Ministry



Our Bureau
New Delhi

The sowing under summer (zaid season) crops, which will be completed this week, reached 86.02 lakh hectares (lh) as of May 22, which is 3 per cent more than the 83.50 lh reported in the year-ago period. The zaid crop is grown before the kharif sowing and after rabi harvest.

Except for paddy and moong (green gram), the area under all other crops has gone up this year. The announcement of a bonus over and above the MSP for the urad crop (black matpe) by the Madhya Pradesh government seems to have worked as farmers have planted over more area.

But the overall acreage under summer moong, in which Madhya Pradesh is the top producer in the country, has reported a dip.

According to a weekly update released by the Agriculture Ministry, paddy sowing was down 4 per cent at 31.05 lh from 32.42 lh, while nutri/coarse cereals areas were 12 per cent up at 16.01 lh against 14.25 lh a year ago.

Among the nutri/coarse cereals, maize area is 18 per cent higher at 10 lh from 8.5

lh, while bajra has reached 5.4 lh against 5.2 lh. Ragi is higher at 0.22 lh from 0.16 lh, and jowar at 0.37 lh from 0.36 lh, the data show.

PULSES AREA RISES

Area under summer pulses reached 27.91 lh from 27.26 lh, in which coverage of moong was reported at 23.01 lh, a notch below 23.49 lh year-ago and urad up 29 per cent at 4.60 lh from 3.58 lh.

The key growers of summer pulses are Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat. Summer pulses are key to offset when there is a fall in kharif crops. In 2025-26, kharif pulses production has been estimated at 7.63 mt from 7.73 mt in 2024-25, and rabi-grown pulses at 16.24 mt against 15.23 mt.

Announcing the bonus of ₹600 per quintal over and above its MSP of ₹7,800/quintal for urad, the Madhya Pradesh government said the step was aimed at encouraging farmers to shift from moong during the summer (zaid) season.

Oilseeds area in this summer season is also higher at 11.04 lh from 9.58 lh, and it includes groundnut at 5.51 lh from 4.20 lh and sesamum at 5.07 lh from 4.96 lh.

Despite US tariffs, gherkin exports surge to a record high of \$307 million in FY26

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Gherkin exports touched a new high both in value and volume during 2025-26 as key buyers, such as Germany, Russia and Canada, scaled up purchase of the pickled cucumbers. The record exports are despite the tariff issue hurting shipments to the US, the largest buyer, and sluggish off-take by key European buyers such as Spain and France.

VOLUME RISE

The gherkin export value during 2025-26 was a tad higher at \$307.61 million over \$306.72 million the previous year.

However, the volume was

Record shipments (India's Gherkin and Cucumber exports)		
Year	Quantity (lakh tonnes)	Value (\$ million)
2025-26	3.145	307.61
2024-25	2.895	306.72
2023-24	2.442	256.58
2022-23	2.276	218.74
2021-22	2.175	199.46

Source: DGCIIS

up by 8 per cent at 3.14 lakh tonnes against 2.89 lakh tonnes.

GM Vinod, President, Indian Gherkin Exporters Association, attributed the growth in value to the appreciating trend in currencies such as the dollar and euro.

Though exports to the US, the largest buyer, were impacted due to tariff issues initially, shipments picked up

after the issue was resolved, he said.

SPAIN, FRANCE OFFTAKE DOWN

As per DGCIIS data, gherkin exports to the US were down by 27 per cent in value at \$53.61 million during FY2025-26 over the previous year's \$73.51 million.

In volume, exports to the US declined 23 per cent to 52,768 tonnes from 68,376 tonnes a year ago.

Also, the off-take from key European buyers Spain and France was lower during the year due to higher domestic stocks, Vinod said.

However, buyers such as Germany, Russia, Canada and the Netherlands increased their purchases from India.

After the US, Germany is the second largest buyer of Indian gherkins with volumes of 35,070 tonnes (29,097 tonnes during 2024-25) valued at \$40.09 million (31.79 million).

Exports to Russia, the third largest buyer, increased to 43,627 tonnes (28,598 tonnes), valued at \$31.76 million (\$25.28 million).

India exports gherkins both in bulk and bottled form. The production and processing of gherkins is concentrated largely in Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh.

Gherkins are produced under a contract farming model with farmers and most of the produce is exported as the pickled cucumber has a negligible domestic market.

Telangana to procure jowar and sunflower at MSP as prices tumble

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

With market prices for jowar and sunflower dipping below the minimum support price (MSP), the Telangana government has stepped in to procure both commodities.

The government has expanded maize procurement by approving an additional bank guarantee of ₹1,867.77 crore, bringing the total expenditure for this season to nearly ₹6,000 crore.

“We have not received a favourable response from the Union government regarding our request to provide financial support for the procurement of these commodities at MSP. So, we have decided to do it ourselves,” Tummala



The market price of jowar has fallen to ₹2,000 per quintal

Nageswara Rao, Minister for Agriculture, said.

BUMPER OUTPUT

The State expected a bumper maize crop of about 43 lakh tonnes from the 2025-26 rabi season, with an average production of 26.50 quintals an acre.

“We have already given a bank guarantee of ₹4,173

crore to the marketing federation to procure maize. We have so far procured 13 lakh tonnes. We have decided to procure another 6.5 lakh tonnes,” the Minister said.

As against an MSP of ₹2,400 per quintal, maize prices are ruling at ₹1,700 per quintal, causing losses to farmers.

The government will also procure jowar (hybrid) at the MSP level for a similar reason. The market price of jowar fell to ₹2,000 per quintal against the MSP of ₹3,699. It said it would spend about ₹1,100 to procure the commodity.

The State pegs jowar output at 4 lakh tonnes.

Similarly, it will procure sunflower at the MSP of ₹7,721 as prices fell to ₹5,376 per quintal.

India cancels soymeal export deals, to import Africa soybeans

Reuters
Mumbai

Indian traders have cancelled 25,000 tonnes of soymeal export contracts for the first time since 2021 and booked 80,000 tonnes of soybean imports from African countries after soaring domestic prices reversed trade flows, trade sources said.

The cancellations are likely to help soymeal suppliers in North and South America boost shipments to Asian buyers who traditionally source from India.

India's soybean purchases are also allowing African exporters to sell the oilseed at a hefty premium to global benchmark prices.

HZL's Rampura Agucha mine gets global 'Zinc Mark' certification

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Hindustan Zinc Ltd's Rampura Agucha Mine has received 'Zinc Mark' certification. It is a globally recognised assurance framework that validates responsible zinc production against internationally benchmarked environmental, social and governance (ESG) standards, responsible sourcing practices and value chain transparency.

A media statement said that the Rampura Agucha mine, which is the world's largest underground zinc-lead mine, is India's first certified mine.

The achievement follows the company's recent Zinc Mark certification for its Chanderiya Smelting Complex, making it the first company in India to offer responsibly sourced zinc

across the given production chain, it said.

3RD PARTY ASSESSMENT

The Zinc Mark certification is awarded following an independent third-party assessment under the Copper Mark Assurance Framework, verifying Rampura Agucha's conformance with internationally recognised responsible production standard across key environmental, social and governance parameters.

The statement said global customers today are placing greater emphasis not only on product quality, but also on how metals are produced, sourced and governed across the supply chain.

Quoting Arun Misra, CEO of Hindustan Zinc, the statement said: “Rampura Agucha Mine receiving the Zinc Mark certification reflects Hindustan Zinc's integrated approach towards respons-

ible production and ESG excellence across its value chain. As global supply chains evolve, customers are increasingly seeking responsibly sourced metals that align with their sustainability priorities and compliance frameworks. This recognition strengthens customer confidence in company as a trusted partner delivering high-quality zinc backed by transparency, responsible production, and globally benchmarked ESG standards.”

The Rampura Agucha mine continues to set industry benchmarks through technology-led mining, operational excellence and sustainable resource management.

The Zinc Mark certification further strengthens Hindustan Zinc's role in enabling responsible and future-ready supply chains for industries.

Go long in aluminium June contracts after exiting at ₹387

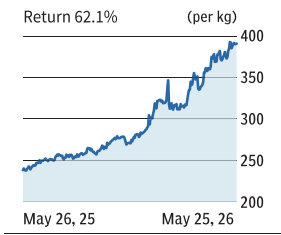
Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Aluminium May futures are now trading at ₹387/kg and June futures at ₹386. Since the former is set to expire on Friday (May 29), we shall consider the June series for analysis.

COMMODITY CALL.

The June aluminium futures broke out of ₹376 a couple of weeks ago, and it extended the rally to hit a high of ₹388 on May 21.

The price action over the past few sessions shows that the contract has been consolidating in the narrow range of ₹382-387. The contract sustains above the resistance-turned-support of ₹376, where the 21-day moving average coincides. Therefore, the inclination is bullish, and the likelihood of a further rally is high.



We anticipate the aluminium futures (June) to surpass ₹387 and rally to ₹400 in the near-term.

On the other hand, if the contract falls and breaches the support at ₹376, the near-term outlook could turn bearish. In such a case, the price could fall to ₹365.

TRADE STRATEGY

Roll over the long position we suggested in May futures at ₹380. That is, exit the trade now at ₹387 and immediately go long on June futures at the current market price (now at ₹386). Target and stop-loss can be ₹400 and ₹375, respectively.

Tea prices drop at Coonoor auctions amid cautious buying

Our Bureau
Kochi

The Coonoor tea auctions witnessed cautious buying from internal buyers and exporters in anticipation of an improvement in crop arrivals in the coming weeks.

Traders pointed out that there were better enquiries at lower prices in Sale 21, besides expectations of better offerings due to an improved crop, thanks to the summer showers in several growing regions.

Global Tea Auctioneers said the sales percentage was on the higher side at 90 per cent for leaf grades out of the 14,37,859 kg offered last week, while it was 87 per cent in dust at 4,48,326 kg.

In CTC leaf, the high-priced teas were generally lower by ₹4-₹5 and more at times, with some withdrawals. The better liquoring



LOSING STEAM. Global Tea Auctioneers said that the sales percentage was on the higher side at 90 per cent for leaf grades

sorts were barely steady and occasionally easier by ₹1-₹2. The medium sorts bolder grades were lower, easier by ₹1-₹2.

CTC DUSTS LOWER

In leaf orthodox, the primary whole leaf grades were barely steady to easier by ₹3-₹4, and occasionally some quality lots sold dearer by ₹3-₹4.

Brokens were barely

steady to lower by ₹2-₹3 with fair withdrawals.

The high-priced teas in dust CTC were lower by ₹8-₹10, and better liquoring sorts were barely steady to dearer by ₹3-₹4. The better medium sorts were barely steady to occasionally dearer by ₹1-₹2. The primary orthodox dust grades were lower by ₹6-₹8 and more at times. However, some lots were withdrawn.

TOKYO SEMINAR. Govt will build ‘transparent, ethical, scalable labour mobility pathways’

QUICKLY.

BluJ Aerospace unveils
Gen #2 prototype aircraft



Hyderabad: BluJ Aerospace has unveiled its Gen #2 prototype aircraft developed on its vertically integrated architecture for next generation intelligent aerial systems (VANTIS) platform. Gen #2 is the first commercial-grade aircraft from VANTIS, purpose-built for heavy-payload logistics. It carries an active payload target of above 200 kg, operates under a 500 kg maximum take-off weight, and uses a lift plus cruise configuration. Fully battery-powered, Gen #2 is now being used for early customer pilots, payload testing and real-world logistics mission evaluations as BluJ expands its missions. **OUR BUREAU**

Air India expands loyalty
programme to AI Express



Mumbai: Air India has expanded its loyalty offering enabling its customers to earn and burn Club Maharaja points on Air India Express flights. Until now Air India's loyalty programme members could earn and redeem points only on its flights and not on those operated by its no-frills brand. This was a pain point for the airline's frequent flyers, and the expansion of the programme will enable them to redeem points on AI Express flights for 55 destinations. The expansion is expected to increase redemption chances and enable more tie-ups with other companies. **OUR BUREAU**

Regional carriers tighten non-fuel spend, cut flights as oil prices bite

VIABILITY DRIVE. Shift reflects industry's effort to navigate fiscal pressures while aiming for sustainability

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Regional carriers are curtailing flights by 3-8 per cent and rationalising their non-fuel expenses as high crude oil prices and weak rupee hurt their earnings.

While the airlines have cut only a handful of flights, they are closely monitoring the cost and demand situation. Star Air Chief Executive Officer Simran Singh Tiwana said several cost optimisation measures have been implemented across the organisation. Crew and maintenance planning has been optimised and vendor contracts are being renegotiated. Star Air is also focusing on improving ancillary revenue, he said.

Alliance Air is reducing non-essential costs such as those related to support services and office transport. The airline has also secured better rates from hotels for



LEAN OPERATING MODEL. FLY91's Manoj Chacko said the airline remains firmly in growth mode with its ATR aircraft fleet giving it better fuel efficiency

crew accommodation. While these would have a minimal impact, the airline is doing whatever possible to reduce its operating cost, a source said.

Alliance Air, which recently secured ₹460 crore financial support from the government, hopes to use the proceeds to repay dues and restore grounded aircraft.

While the increased fuel prices has widened the cost and revenue mismatch for

Alliance Air (it operates only 10 of its 21 aircraft), the management is hopeful of reducing losses going forward.

"Our costs will start coming down once we bring more aircraft into operation," the source added.

FEWER JUNE FLIGHTS

In the January-March quarter, four regional airlines (Alliance Air, FLY91, IndiaOne Air and Star Air), collectively flew 5.5 lakh pas-

sengers. The airlines operate a mix of UDAN (*Ude Deshka Aam Nagrik*) and non-UDAN routes and together they have a share of 1.3 per cent of domestic traffic.

The airlines have scheduled fewer flights in June compared to May, data from aviation analytics firm Cirium show.

While IndiaOne has cut flights by around 3 per cent, Alliance Air and Star Air have scheduled 6-8 per cent fewer flights month-on-month basis.

Cirium data show FLY91's flights increasing by a modest 0.9 per cent over May. Tiwana said the slight adjustment in scheduled flights during June is primarily linked to the current geopolitical situation along with seasonal demand trends and operational optimisation.

Manoj Chacko, CEO and Managing Director of FLY91, said the airline remains firmly in growth mode with its ATR aircraft fleet giving it

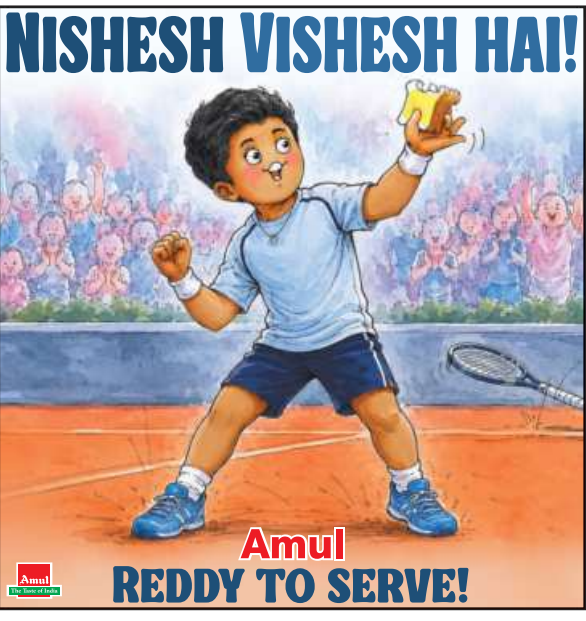
better fuel efficiency compared to larger aircraft. This along with our lean operating model has helped us save costs, he said.

"Recently, we have expanded operations with new routes including Hyderabad-Rajahmundry, Hyderabad-Vijayawada and have added flights between Pune and Goa," he said.

NEW SERVICES

New services are also being planned to Mangaluru and Tirupati. "We have not seen any meaningful drop in demand. On the contrary, demand on our core regional sectors remains stable," Chacko added.

"Our Indian portfolio is performing in line with expectations. India remains a key strategic market for us and we continue to see strong long term demand for regional aircraft across the country," said Abhineet Awasthi, Sales Director of leasing firm TrueNoord.



Smoke detected on IndiGo flight at Bengaluru; passengers safe

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

An IndiGo flight bound for Chennai from Bengaluru was evacuated on Tuesday after smoke was detected in the aircraft while it was taxiing for departure.

In an official statement, an IndiGo spokesperson said smoke was noticed on flight 6E 6017 operating from Bengaluru to Chennai while

the aircraft was taxiing towards the runway on May 26.

"In the interest of safety, an immediate evacuation was carried out and all the relevant authorities were informed," the airline said.

The airline said all passengers and crew members were safe and had been moved to the terminal, where assistance was being provided by IndiGo teams.

An alternative aircraft has been arranged.

Airtel's 'Priority Postpaid' prompts Parliamentary panel scrutiny

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Amid a growing debate triggered by the launch of the Airtel Priority Postpaid plan, a Parliamentary panel on Tuesday asked the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) and the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) to study the impact of 5G network slicing services in countries such as Singapore and the UK, while also examining whether the interests of India's largely prepaid mobile subscriber base are adequately protected.

The Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology, headed by BJP MP Nishikant Dubey, also decided to call major digital and social media companies, including Meta, X, Google and Amazon, for discussions on net neutrality and preferential access practices.

The meeting was convened to review "Quality of Service (QoS) Standards and Consumer Protection in Telecom Sector", with a specific focus on net neutrality.

The deliberations assume significance following the recent launch of Airtel Priority

The panel also flagged concerns over the impact on prepaid subscribers, who account for nearly 90% of India's user base

Postpaid, India's first commercially announced 5G network slicing-based consumer offering.

In a communication to users, Airtel said the technology had already been deployed in several Western

markets and would allow the company to provide enhanced network capabilities exclusively to its Priority Postpaid customers.

The move, however, has sparked concerns over whether telecom operators may begin offering differentiated quality of service to select categories of subscribers, potentially undermining the principle of equal internet access.

According to a person familiar with the discussions, the committee sought detailed submissions from DoT and TRAI on how similar services have affected net neutrality frameworks globally.

"The committee asked DoT and TRAI to present a study on the impact of 5G slicing in countries such as Singapore and the UK, among others. It also discussed what implications this could have for net neutrality, which is based on the principle of equality," the person said.

Members of the panel also reportedly flagged concerns over the impact on prepaid subscribers, who account for nearly 90 per cent of India's mobile user base.

"Nearly 90 per cent users are having prepaid mobile

connections. How can their rights be bypassed? DoT and TRAI have been asked to give a detailed response," the person added.

PREFERENTIAL ACCESS

5G network slicing enables telecom operators to partition a single physical network into multiple virtual networks, each optimised for specific performance requirements such as speed, latency or reliability. While one slice may support high-speed consumer broadband, others can be tailored for applications such as autonomous vehicles, remote health-

care or large-scale IoT connectivity.

After the meeting, Dubey said the committee was examining whether telecom operators and digital platforms were creating preferential access structures for specific categories of users, including postpaid subscribers and paying customers on online platforms.

"We have to look after 140 crore people. All of them should get equal rights," Dubey said, while clarifying that the panel had not yet reached any conclusions and that discussions would continue in the coming weeks.





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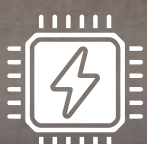
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Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSE CI
P&G Health	5726.00	5652.50	5749.00	5760.00	5599.00	15.62	6739.00	4707.00	...	
Pace Digitek	190.40	201.18	199.00	210.50	176.20	2142.83	84.14	231.95	139.81	
Page Ind	38545.00	38980.00	38900.00	38970.00	38095.00	130.50	30470.60	29800.00	...	54.383246.00
Pakistan	90.58	99.80	98.00	102.00	92.80	112.83	226.78	74.12	...	
Panacea Bio [1]	419.05	424.00	420.00	439.20	420.00	104.57	515.55	293.10	...	424.05
Panachee PH	348.15	351.30	351.65	360.07	341.05	10.76	472.15	174.80	...	
Pankaj	39.58	39.05	39.35	40.00	38.50	29.50	39.50	39.50	...	
Paradeepdiesl	128.61	127.64	128.61	130.99	127.10	132.01	346.83	234.39	...	17.35020.00
Parag Milk	211.71	211.27	211.27	213.54	210.30	55.62	377.20	178.35	...	17.21145.00
PARAMUD	65.35	66.52	67.00	68.00	66.10	10507.33	69.75	28.40	...	34.6661.00
Paras Defen	85.74	85.15	85.80	87.05	83.85	1897.21	75.80	46.00	...	
Partek Hotels	122.33	123.33	123.00	126.06	122.21	14.72	173.20	95.10	...	
Partek MediCo	279.09	287.28	288.20	289.07	274.10	1260.26	289.07	138.10	...	
PashupatiCot	95.98	108.96	96.70	100.00	95.19	51.16	1036.40	67.75	...	
Pasupati Cer	57.52	58.32	59.25	59.86	56.06	155.65	63.50	40.10	...	
Patanjali Ed	46.85	46.75	46.77	46.89	46.50	1730.80	1961.80	438.00	...	
Patel enegg [1]	26.28	27.77	26.22	28.30	26.26	88.86	46.43	22.08	...	27.80
Patel Int	13.04	13.06	13.06	13.06	13.04	434.97	13.80	19.20	...	10.1337.00
Patel Retail	199.76	199.12	196.16	197.38	192.10	99.81	305.00	150.25	...	
Pat Fintech	131.50	178.90	131.00	180.40	117.30	709.30	378.00	136.30	...	
PayTM	1097.10	1163.10	1103.40	1136.50	1098.60	3441.43	1381.80	849.20	...	
PC Jeweller [1]	8.92	9.12	9.15	9.33	8.91	6256.33	19.65	7.45	...	9.133
PCBL	294.25	298.20	294.00	295.50	288.75	52.04	437.30	226.50	...	
PCEN	29.50	29.50	29.50	29.50	29.50	29.50	29.50	29.50	...	
PENNAR IND [1]	151.46	156.91	153.98	157.99	156.56	118.66	179.28	128.90	...	21.5167.00
PERSISTENT [1]	503.08	510.05	503.08	513.90	502.01	45.03	6597.00	4450.00	...	47.5625.00
Petronet LNG	282.25	280.20	280.00	282.07	271.15	166.99	43.26	23.55	...	11.28025.00
PETROBRAS	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	...	
PE Electro [1]	471.25	466.95	471.00	484.01	465.05	218.77	836.35	438.65	...	107.467.00
PGL [1]	1602.80	1637.80	1622.10	1645.60	1610.10	126.80	1933.90	1180.00	...	108.1638.00
PICOT	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	...	
PhysicsWall	99.99	122.03	112.33	111.30	111.75	389.64	161.99	77.72	...	
PI INDUS [1]	284.00	2837.00	2845.00	2859.00	2810.00	174.35	4323.00	2700.00	...	28.1838.00
Piccadilly	59.95	58.45	59.70	60.00	57.80	384.00	405.00	515.00	...	
PIDF	14.00	14.00	14.00	14.00	14.00	14.00	14.00	14.00	...	63.1463.00
Pine Labs	14.20	13.74	15.01	15.28	13.57	1526.68	28.04	13.52	...	
Piramal Fin	1942.90	1949.20	1945.00	1972.00	1935.10	33.32	2730.20	1260.00	...	
PIT	17.86	17.86	17.86	17.86	17.86	17.86	17.86	17.86	...	
Pitti Eng	94.36	92.88	94.36	94.80	92.11	24.53	106.05	67.20	...	36.9239.00
Pix Transm	152.00	154.00	151.55	154.00	150.05	31.11	170.60	122.00	...	
Platinum	22.59	22.54	22.28	23.00	22.44	22.51	12.30	34.20	...	183.50
PLN	19.00	19.00	19.00	19.00	19.00	19.00	19.00	19.00	...	
Pnb Bkts	78.28	78.26	79.00	80.44	77.80	57.83	119.84	58.75	...	8.7828.00
PNB Housing	1085.00	1092.00	1084.10	1098.00	1078.10	66.29	2141.55	730.00	...	12.10922.00
PNC	584.70	584.70	584.70	584.70	584.70	584.70	584.70	584.70	...	
PNG Res Dev	40.95	39.72	40.00	40.70	39.05	104.55	47.75	32.45	...	
Pokarna Ltd [1]	85.40	83.16	85.00	86.66	82.02	115.21	1147.35	692.55	...	83.869.00
Poly Medic [1]	1847.00	1439.00	1500.00	1500.00	1428.00	57.25	241.30	1184.00	...	43.1493.00
Polymer	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	...	
Polyplex	913.55	907.00	918.65	923.70	902.80	52.25	139.60	743.00	...	48.905.00
PonawallaFin	398.90	396.55	400.95	405.00	393.45	129.93	57.10	361.20	...	
PPF	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	...	
Power Finan	438.00	433.70	440.30	440.00	435.54	464.48	48.45	33.05	...	7.4335.00
Power grid	29.35	29.25	29.50	29.95	29.25	56.25	95.80	24.00	...	17.2926.00
Power Instru	105.18	106.38	107.98	109.55	103.53	195.45	105.45	105.45	...	
Power Trd	191.32	191.32	191.32	191.32	191.32	191.32	191.32	191.32	...	14.1915.00
POWERICA	555.20	574.00	569.00	579.00	555.00	250.16	35.80	365.10	...	
POWERMECH	2547.10	2493.90	2560.00	2560.00	2480.00	62.79	3415.45	1718.00	...	26.2491.95
PPS	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	...	
Pr Jraj Indt [1]	39.85	39.85	39.85	39.85	39.85	39.85	39.85	39.85	...	39.85
Prakash Ind	141.29	149.99	141.29	151.84	141.29	115.52	19.10	110.00	...	8.14970.00
Prakash Pipe	20.21	20.28	19.99	20.07	19.80	11.72	9.30	163.21	...	
Prakash Ppt	132.06	132.06	132.06	132.06	132.06	132.06	132.06	132.06	...	
Precam	154.24	154.31	154.99	155.99	153.10	11.08	26.33	104.05	...	45.154.00
Precision Wr [1]	442.60	457.05	445.00	460.00	440.16	50.47	166.50	54.47	...	45.475.00
Prerem	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	...	
Premier Exp [1]	98.05	101.60	100.80	102.40	100.01	36.96	91.30	66.00	...	
Premier Exp [2]	74.60	72.55	72.00	73.90	71.60	1077.77	79.60	378.80	...	83.726.45
Princedev Est	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	...	
Princal Ltd [1]	56.70	56.20	56.05	56.40	55.95	51.95	69.45	41.25	...	33.5617.00
Prince Pipe	27.15	26.75	26.25	27.35	26.00	44.35	34.87	20.05	...	
Prism Cement	117.52	124.81	118.35	126.60	117.45	155.99	172.15	115.70	...	12.1249.00
Prism Ind	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	...	
Procter&Gam	965.09	987.00	965.09	987.00	965.09	13.57	145.65	89.95	...	30.9880.75
Prostarfintm	14.28	14.31	14.30	14.60	14.21	40.49	17.47	25.49	...	108.00
Prostarfintm	62.30	62.30	62.30	62.30	62.30	62.30	62.30	62.30	...	
Prozone Rity	51.28	52.85	51.60	54.00	51.00	57.16	17.72	33.63	...	
Prudent Corp	2680.27	2722.60	2680.00	2750.00	2680.00	15.34	3098.00	2121.00	...	
PSPPROJECT	71.25	83.65	77.60	84.00	73.75	278.45	103.80	56.30	...	83.847.00
PTCL	102.00	103.00	102.00	103.00	102.00	103.00	103.00	103.00	...	
PTCJIN SER	30.64	30.66	30.60	31.13	30.59	41.93	44.49	23.78	...	6.3068.00
Punjab Ref [1]	106.26	105.91	106.13	107.20	105.42	26.98	36.15	98.50	...	7.105.95
Punjab Sptm	24.15	24.15	24.15	24.15	24.15	24.15	24.15	24.15	...	
Puravankara [1]	22.89	22.22	22.80	22.85	22.21	15.97	33.88	160.00	...	75.2245.00
PVP Ven	61.78	25.92	26.30	26.60	25.80	47.27	39.80	18.26	...	
PVR Inox	981.40	967.70	984.90	992.00	965.00	202.61	1249.70	907.40	...	
Q										
Quadrant Fut	288.65	302.95	281.20	326.95	281.20	67.69	117.31	248.55	...	
QUESS	20.86	20.84	20.84	20.86	20.30	130.78	33.66	166.05	...	14.205.10
Quickheal	155.20	195.51	165.15	198.69	192.21	62.82	416.00	125.00	...	194.15
R										
RACIL Gearch	143.92	136.66	140.00	146.00	135.00	33.39	1691.90	805.00	...	
Radiant Jew	56.70	56.70	56.70	56.70	56.70	56.70	56.70	56.70	...	
Radiant Ind	352.90	357.40	355.00	359.00	353.60	191.92	365.00	247.15	...	78.3583.65
Raghuvar Prod.	91.25	94.30	94.20	99.00	93.90	176.84	105.50	561.30	...	
Rail	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	32.00	...	
Rail India	172.26	179.98	172.26	179.98	172.26	179.98	172.26	179.98	...	172.25
Rainbow Ch	135.00	136.00	135.00	136.00	134.80	147.68	164.50	1084.00	...	
RAJSPJ	17.78	17.98	17.72	18.50	16.69	34.06	49.11	119.90	...	14.178.55
Rajshree M	3.80	3.80	3.80	3.80	3.80	3.80	3.80	3.80	...	
Rajputa Eng	57.87	57.35	58.00	58.29	57.30	168.38	14.88	46.00	...	
Rajputa Sta	131.61	131.75	132.00	137.40	130.25	160.40	14.90	101.70	...	
Rajputa Sta	415.10	415.10	415.10	415.10	415.10	415.10	415.10	415.10	...	
Rallia India [1]	253.15	254.90	253.15	260.20	252.20	56.36	38.65	216.10	...	25.255.00
Ram Ratna Wr	40.54	47.00	46.85	47.50	45.60	56.17	78.95	268.00	...	
Rama Shil [1]	5.31	5.32	5.39	5.39	5.30	344.85	14.32	34.40	...	5.33
Ramco Ind [1]	42.50	47.42	47.42	49.48	47.42	49.48	47.42	49.48	...	72.4743.00
Ramco Cement	90.65	89.16	91.00	91.35	87.90	52.68	141.20	860.20	...	82.893.05
Ramco Indus [1]	291.90	298.15	291.90	300.70	289.20	99.68	398.05	230.70	...	26.296.30
Ramco INFRA	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	13.00	...	
Rane Holdi	129.20	138.47	138.50	140.91	13					